EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Why Believe the Redemption Will Come?

Given Monday 23 June 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 8:1-2

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 8 (The Final Redemption), Chapters 1 and 2

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 23 June 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Where We Are in the Book

The first shiur on the eighth essay. The Rabbi began by placing it in the structure of the whole book, which falls into three sections:

Section	Essays	Theme
1	**1 and 2**	**God Himself**: creation from nothing, and Hashem's unity and how we describe Him
2	**3 to 6**	**The human being and his relationship with God**: Torah, mitzvot and prophecy (3), free will and obedience (4), mitzvot, sins and teshuvah (5), and the soul, our identity (6)
3	**7 to 9**	**The end of days**, both in this world and in the next

Essay 7, finished last time, dealt with **תחיית המתים**. Essay 9 will deal with **עולם הבא**, the new world, and reward and punishment there. Between them, still in this world, comes Essay 8: **the redemption and Mashiach**.

What is redemption? What is Mashiach? Is there a fixed time for him to come? Can we hasten his arrival? Has he already come? What is his essence? These are the questions Saadia takes up over nine chapters. Essay 10, on general musar and conduct, "is not a philosophical work. That's just a conclusion to his book about the best way we as Jews and as humans should behave."

The plan is to finish Essay 8 by Tishah b'Av. Tonight: **Chapters 1 and 2**, the purpose of the redemption and the traditional proofs that it will come. Chapters 3 to 5 will deal with **when** it will come.

The essay is headed **מאמר השמיני: גאולה אחרונה**, the final redemption, meaning the final redemption **in this world**.

A word about the timing

The Rabbi said how appropriate it felt to be preparing this essay "with everything happening in Israel and Iran." But he added a clear caution: "I don't like people who come along and say this is Mashiach times, and Mashiach's about to come, and this is the war of Gog uMagog. I think it's hubris to be able to think we know when Mashiach is coming." What we can say, and what this chapter shows, is that **the Land of Israel is an essential part of Mashiach**. When we are sovereign and gathered into the land, "this is certainly the beginning of the Messianic times." How long that goes on, decades or longer, nobody knows.

Chapter 1: The Four Elements of the Redemption

הודיענו אלהינו על ידי נביאיו שיגאלנו קהל בני ישראל מן העוני אשר אנחנו בו, ויקבץ תפוצותינו ממזרח וממערב מצפון ומים, ויביאנו אל עיר קדשו וישכיננו בו, ונהיה סגולתו ונחלתו

Hashem has told us through all His prophets that the redemption will bring four things:

1. **Relief from our suffering.** "He will redeem us from the affliction we are in." Since the destruction of the Second Temple in 70 CE we have been through almost 2,000 years of pogroms, holocausts and every kind of terrible situation. The first purpose of the redemption is to save us from that.
2. **The ingathering.** He will gather us from east and west, north and south. Jews have ended up in every part of the world: "that's part of our nature."
3. **To the Land.** He will bring us to His holy city, Yerushalayim and Eretz Yisrael, and settle us there.
4. **We will be His *segulah* and His inheritance.**

What is a *segulah*?

The phrase **עם סגולה** comes from Parashat Yitro, just before the revelation at Sinai: **והייתם לי סגולה מכל העמים**. It is often translated "chosen people," and its meaning is debated among the Rishonim. Saadia seems to hold that it is a **peculiar and unique quality of Am Yisrael that will be expressed in Eretz Yisrael**. We are an *am segulah* now, but it is not yet manifest.

So even if every Jew made aliyah, and the country thrived economically and militarily, that would fulfil points two and three. But "we still have the pressures and we're not sovereign and we still have the enemies around us. That's not number four yet." The fourth point is when it is **clear to the world around us that we are God's people**, "and that's not clear at the moment, unfortunately."

The sources

There are many, but Saadia brings Zechariah:

(Zechariah 8:7-8) **הנני מושיע את עמי מארץ מזרח ומארץ מבוא השמש, והבאתי אתם ושכנו בתוך ירושלים**

"I will save My people" (relief), "from the land of the east and the land of the setting sun" (ingathering), "and I will bring them, and they will dwell in Yerushalayim" (the land). The prophets, he says, expanded on this until they filled many books.

And it goes back to Moshe. "I don't want you to think this is just something from the later prophets." The very first prophet already promised it:

ושב ה׳ אלהיך את שבותך ורחמך, ושב וקבצך מכל העמים אשר הפיצך ה׳ אלהיך שמה. אם יהיה נדחך בקצה השמים משם יקבצך ה׳ אלהיך ומשם יקחך. והביאך ה׳ אלהיך אל הארץ (Devarim 30:3-5)

So redemption is not only that we will live good lives and be saved from the attacks we suffer. "It's more than that, it's the *brit*, it's the covenant with the land." Our sovereignty and military strength in the land are an essential part of it. "Again, I'm not saying we are in the messianic times... No one has the ability, I strongly believe, to say when."

Not Philosophy but Tradition

והסתכלתי בענין הזה בדרך עיון...

Saadia notes that this subject, unlike the earlier essays, **cannot be argued philosophically**. When he wrote about God, creation from nothing and free will, he brought rational arguments, and that was the whole thrust of those essays. Here he does not, because Mashiach is a matter of **tradition**. There is one exception, which he will reach later: his philosophical arguments **against those who believe Mashiach has already come**.

Still, from a traditional perspective the redemption is necessary, **for four reasons**.

1. The prophets' signs will be fulfilled

Moshe made many signs and promised the redemption. So did Yeshayahu, Yirmiyahu and the other prophets. The God who sent them and gave them those signs will certainly fulfil their words:

מקים דבר עבדו ועצת מלאכיו ישלים (Yeshayahu 44:26)

2. God is just

As established in Essay 2, Hashem is perfect and does no injustice. "And look, this is Rav Saadia writing this a thousand years ago. This is before the Holocaust in Germany, before the pogroms in Ukraine, before the blood libels in Syria and in Iraq." Even then, he says, we had suffered a very long time.

Without doubt, **part of our suffering is punishment and part of it is a test**. But either way, **each has a limit**. A punishment or a test cannot go on forever. When it ends, we must be healed and rewarded:

כי נרצה עונה, כי לקחה מיד ה׳ כפלים בכל חטאתיה (Yeshayahu 40:2)

Saadia is speaking here about our **national** history. Justice means that the time must come when Hashem says, "That's it. Now it's time to reward you."

3. God is faithful to His own promises

Leaving aside what He promised through the prophets, Hashem Himself has promised, and He keeps His word:

יבש חציר נבל ציץ, ודבר אלהינו יקום לעולם (Yeshayahu 40:8)

Everything physical withers and fades, but the word of Hashem is everlasting.

4. Compare it with Egypt

The first promise Hashem ever made us was about Egypt, told to Avraham in a single line:

וגם את הגוי אשר יעבדו דן אנכי, ואחרי כן יצאו ברכש גדול (Bereishit 15:14)

That was all. And look what we saw: the plagues, the splitting of the sea, the manna and the quail, the revelation at Sinai, the sun standing still for Yehoshua. **All the more so** for the final redemption, about which we have been promised so much more, and which will be at least **double** the first, to match all the affliction we have been through:

תחת בשתכם משנה, וכלמה ירנו חלקם, לכן בארצם משנה יירשו (Yeshayahu 61:7)

The prophet even calls all our suffering, in the grand scheme of things, **a small moment**: "I know we've been through so much, two millennia of suffering nationally," but the redemption will be far greater:

ברגע קטן עזבתיך, וברחמים גדלים אקבצך (Yeshayahu 54:7)

והיטבך והרבך מאבתיך (Devarim 30:5)

This, the Rabbi explained, is why the prophets so often compare the end of days to Egypt. We were stuck there as a nation, and Hashem took us out. "Yes, there were certain failures, with the spies, with Korach and so on. But look at the whole picture": the revelation, the land, the conquest, hundreds of years of sovereignty. The end will be greater still:

כימי צאתך מארץ מצרים אראנו נפלאות (Michah 7:15)

That is why we are always told to remember Egypt: it is the beginning of our redemption, and a reminder that it will happen again.

Waiting Without Despair

ועל כן אנחנו סובלים ומיחלים... לא נקוץ ולא נכסוף, אך נוסיף חזק ואמץ

Therefore, says Saadia, we wait patiently. We do not grow frustrated or angry, but add strength and courage, as it says: **חזקו ויאמץ לבבכם כל המיחלים לה׳**. "And again, this is him writing a thousand years ago." A thousand years on we still do not have the full redemption. "Certainly the State of Israel is a partial redemption, because we have our land back," though we are not yet fully sovereign.

Why do we look like fools?

Other nations look at us and wonder: what is this nation waiting for? When someone comes to convert, the Gemara tells us to ask him why he would want to join a nation that is oppressed, belittled and scorned, "and still we say this till today." The Rabbi called it "a historical fact, not a tradition or belief": no other nation has been through so much suffering and oppression. The onlookers must think we are fools for holding on to our faith.

Saadia says they think so **because they have not been through what we have been through, and have not seen what we have seen.** He gives two analogies.

The seed. Someone who has never seen wheat grow watches a man throw seed into a furrow in the ground and thinks he is a fool. He does not realise that he himself is the fool, until the crop comes back thirty-fold.

הזרעים בדמעה ברנה יקצרו (Tehillim 126:5)

"Beautiful verse. Those who sow with tears will reap with song." We have planted with all the tears our people have shed through the generations, "and especially recently," and we will harvest with joy.

The child. Someone who has never seen children brought up watches a parent bear all the toil of raising a son and asks: what can he possibly hope to gain from this? "Just think about how much effort, those who are parents, we put in for our children, from when they're babies all the way through." Then the child grows, becomes wise, rises to some great position, and the onlooker realises how wrong he was. That is why the redemption is compared to the birth of a son: **בטרם יבוא חבל לה והמליטה זכר**. You go through the pain, and at the end there is a child who brings you happiness.

Tears and harvest today

The Rabbi applied this, carefully, to the present. "God forbid to put the 7th of October into any kind of context, because of the suffering of the families and the people who died and were injured, and still now the hostages who are still there, the fifty hostages. May HaKadosh Baruch Hu bring them out soon." But almost two years on, we can look back at that terrible day, when we asked what good could possibly come from it, and see something emerging: the defeat of Israel's enemies, Hamas, Hezbollah, Syria, and now Iran. "We planted in tears, and now, *be'ezrat Hashem*, we'll see the full sovereignty of Am Yisrael, may it be in our days."

Chapter 1 in short

1. **The purpose of the redemption:** relief from oppression, the ingathering, the ingathering to Eretz Yisrael, and there being manifest as God's unique nation.
2. **The proofs** are from tradition, not philosophy: the prophets' words, God's justice, God's own promise, and the comparison with Egypt.
3. **Encouragement:** do not despair. Like seed in the ground and a child being raised, what looks like waste brings joy at the end.

Chapter 2, Part 1: Of Course He Can

Chapter 2 continues the encouragement, and then turns to the question of **when**. The Rabbi noted that Saadia has not yet used the word Mashiach at all. He calls the essay *Ge'ulah*, redemption. The person who will usher it in, and the fact that Saadia literally holds there will be **two Mashiachs**, comes later.

Saadia now brings four images:

1. One for whom **the heavens are measured by a span**: how could it be hard for Him to send us the redemption?
2. One for whom **all the waters are like the spread of a palm**: how could it be hard for Him to gather our scattered ones from among them?
3. One for whom **all the dust of the earth is a measured thing**: how could it not be easy for Him to gather its exiles?

4. One for whom **the mountains are weighed** on a scale: how could it not be near for Him to rebuild our holy mountain?

Why these four? Because they come straight from the haftarah of Shabbat Nachamu, read after Tishah b'Av:

מי מדד בשעלו מים, ושמים בזרת תכן, וכל בשלש עפר הארץ, ושקל בפלס הרים וגבעות במאזנים (Yeshayahu 40:12)

No human can measure the waters, the heavens, the dust and the mountains, "even nowadays." If Hashem can, He can certainly bring the redemption.

Saadia continues with two more:

- For Him **all the nations are like drops from a bucket**: how would He not humble them before us? **הן גוים כמר מדלי וכשחק מאזנים נחשבו** (Yeshayahu 40:15).
- For Him shaking the wicked off the earth is like gathering up a sheet and shaking it out: **לאחז בכנפות הארץ וינערו רשעים ממנה** (Iyov 38:13).

"I could have just said," Saadia writes, "that one who created all this from nothing" can certainly redeem us, since creation is far greater than redemption. But he chose to point to the simple images in the verses themselves.

He has not forgotten us

It is forbidden to think that Hashem does not know our situation, or that He will not act for us, or that He has no mercy, or that He cannot save us and does not hear our prayers. The Rabbi put it in the language of omnipotence, omnibenevolence and omniscience: all three are behind the promise.

למה תאמר יעקב ותדבר ישראל נסתרה דרכי מה׳ (Yeshayahu 40:27)

הן לא קצרה יד ה׳ מהושיע (Yeshayahu 59:1)

כי אל רחום ה׳ אלהיך, לא ירפך ולא ישחיתך (Devarim 4:31)

"Sometimes we feel we pray and we don't get answered. Never think they're not answered." And unlike what other religions have claimed about Am Yisrael, we have never been forsaken.

The Rabbi spoke personally here. "Especially over the past week, how HaKadosh Baruch Hu never forsakes us. I think we're living through miracles, honestly." People say that if Hashem did miracles today, as in the old days, they would believe. "If you can't see how a tiny, tiny nation, so small, surrounded by enemies, has been able to destroy one after the other all of them, you'll never see the hand of Hashem."

Chapter 2, Part 2: Two Possible Times for the Redemption

Now Saadia begins a theme that runs over the next few chapters.

אבל הדבר שאנחנו מאמינים בו, הוא שם לשעבודנו שני זמנים: אחד מהם זמן התשובה, והשני זמן הקץ, ואיזה מהם שיקדים תבוא הגאולה

Our exile has **two possible ends**:

1. **The time of teshuvah.** The redemption can come at any time, based on our conduct. There are many Midrashim to this effect, such as the famous one that if all Israel kept Shabbat, the redemption would come.
2. **The time of the *ketz***, the fixed end time, whatever it is. Saadia will discuss when that is in the coming chapters.

Whichever comes first, the redemption comes.

If our teshuvah is complete, the *ketz* does not matter. It will be as Parashat Nitzavim says: when all these things come upon you, the blessing and the curse, **ושבת עד ה׳ אלהיך ושמעת בקלו**, you return to Hashem and listen to His voice, **ושב ה׳ אלהיך את שבותך ורחמך**. If our teshuvah falls short, we remain until the *ketz*.

But what about those who deserve it now?

How is it fair to the people who have done full teshuvah? Saadia answers that, as with every collective calamity (famine, sword, plague), **some are being punished and some are being tested**, and those who are tested will be rewarded later.

- In **the Flood** there were young children who died. They will be rewarded.
- In **Egypt**, Saadia has no doubt there were many righteous people who suffered under the bondage until the redemption came.

So nobody can say to us, "If there were righteous people among you, you would have been redeemed." Saadia points to Moshe, Aharon and Miriam, who were certainly righteous. ("Well, not Moshe, but Aharon and Miriam did at least" live through the bondage.) They went through the exile in Egypt, and the redemption did not come for them until its time. **Redemption is national, not individual.** Many of us may deserve it, but it comes to the nation as a whole.

The source: Sanhedrin

> **רבי אליעזר אומר: אם ישראל עושין תשובה נגאלין, ואם לאו אין נגאלין. אמר לו רבי יהושע: אם אין עושין תשובה אין נגאלין? אלא הקדוש ברוך הוא מעמיד להן מלך שגזרותיו קשות כהמן, וישראל עושין תשובה ומחזירן למוטב** (Sanhedrin 97b)

Rabbi Eliezer says redemption depends on teshuvah. Rabbi Yehoshua asks: if they never do teshuvah, will it never come? Rather, Hashem will raise up a king with decrees as harsh as Haman's, and Israel will do teshuvah. The Gemara goes on to reconcile two phrases in one verse, **בעתה** ("in its time") and **אחישנה** ("I will hasten it"): **זכו, אחישנה. לא זכו, בעתה.** If they merit it, I will hasten it. If not, it will come in its time.

Teshuvah will happen either way

The Rabbi drew out a point Saadia makes later: **teshuvah is going to have to happen.** If we do it of our own free will, the redemption will come now, nationally. If not, then in the prelude to the *ketz* we will be **forced into teshuvah** by suffering. That is where the wars of **Gog uMagog** come in, which Saadia will discuss.

"I don't know if you've seen, there have been clips of secular Israeli presenters saying Tehillim on TV and recognising the hand of Hashem. This is what we mean when we say forced into teshuvah. We're being forced into teshuvah now, and *be'ezrat Hashem*, may our nation

recognise that, all of us across the world, as soon as possible, and then redemption will come of its own accord."

Summary

1. **Structure of the book:** Essays 1-2 on God, 3-6 on the human being and God, 7-9 on the end of days. Essay 8 is the redemption in this world.
2. **Four elements of the redemption:** relief from suffering, ingathering, return to Eretz Yisrael, and being manifest there as Hashem's *segulah*. Promised by all the prophets, beginning with Moshe.
3. **Four traditional reasons it must come:** the prophets' words, God's justice (punishment and test must end), God's own promise, and the precedent of Egypt, which the final redemption will at least double.
4. **Waiting with courage:** like seed sown in tears and a child raised with toil, what looks foolish to onlookers ends in joy.
5. **He can and He will:** the One who measures the waters, heavens, earth and mountains can redeem us. He has not forgotten or forsaken us.
6. **Two times for the redemption:** through teshuvah, at any time, or at the fixed *ketz*. Redemption is national; and before the *ketz* we will be brought to teshuvah one way or another.

Coming Up

Next week, at the usual time of 6 o'clock: **Chapters 3 and 4**, on the *ketz*, what it is and what will happen then, before Saadia turns to the details of Mashiach himself. The Rambam shiur the following evening was moved to 8:30 to 9:30.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/wvvocW1WReo · More shiurim: rabbikada.com